A GENERATIONAL SHIFT

How young workers are changing the rules of the workplace



88%

of Gen Zers were considering a job switch in 2023, said a LinkedIn survey



61%

of them prefer companies that value mental health over salary, as per a survey by the RPG Group



64%

said they preferred flexible workplace options, as per the RPG Group



52%

consider potential for skill growth as a crucial factor in a job, says LinkedIn India data

9 MONTHS

Average length of stay in a job for a Gen Zer, as per a study by Xpheno

NEARLY HALF

of Gen Z workers want a personal connection with the top management, as per a 2022 survey by Deloitte

BREAKS ARE IN

Many groups are helping Gen Z be productive during study or work breaks. GapX at Ashoka University is one such group

ONE-THIRD

The share of Gen Z respondents in the 2021 Deloitte Global Gen Z and Millennial Survey who said they took time off work due to stress caused during Covid months

WORK-LIFE BALANCE

is what the Gen Z prioritises. Working long hours, on weekends and being available 24/7 to their bosses is a strict no-no. A 2021 study by Adobe showed 57 per cent Gen Zers felt the pressure to be reachable at all hours

respondents felt financially secure.

Naturally then, for the tech-savvy, ever-advanced Gen Zers, no workplace is too dear, and no job too precious to part with—especially those that require peace of mind as a trade-off. According to a report last year by LinkedIn, 88 per cent of Gen Z professionals in India were considering a job switch in 2023. This is the generation with the highest churn rate. A study by hiring solutions company Xpheno, which studied data of 5 million active workers, showed that those between 22 and 24 years of age spent an average of just nine months with a company and had a churn rate of 20 per cent, compared to 3.8 years for those above 36 years of age, who have a churn rate of just 5 per cent.

The 'Great Resignation', as many have chosen to call it in recent years, is also the fallout of the way the nature of work changed during the Covid-19 pandemic, with hybrid jobs blurring the boundaries of professional and personal space. A 2021 study by Adobe saw 57 per cent of Gen Zers admitting that they felt the pressure of being reachable at all hours—the most of any age group—and 74 per cent saying they would switch jobs for better work-life balance. No wonder, Gen Z has had enough, and many, particularly those who are not constrained by financial pressures, are no longer willing to put up with exploitative workplaces. Twenty-year-old Sarah Bothra from Mumbai, for instance, holds no regrets about quitting her marketing internship to raise capital for her own marketing firm instead. "I want to work from home. I feel I am at my creative best in a space that I am comfortable in. But offices these days still insist that productivity is measured by the hours clocked and not the work done. So I would rather earn less by being an entrepreneur than be someone's slave."

DOING IT THEIR OWN WAY

Make no mistake, though—Gen Z is not delusional or unaroused. Far from it, it's raring to do things its own way. From starting their own companies to enrolling for online courses, Gen Z simply has a different idea of what work should mean. Sagarikka S., 23, for example, wrote a whole book in her gap year and took up internships to ensure that her time off was productive. Many 'gap year communities' have come up in recent years to guide people who want to take a break from study or work. GapX, a group of 40-odd students at Ashoka University, is one such community. Several IITs have also been encouraging their students to pursue their entrepreneurial ideas first and defer placements for a few months after graduation.

"I think this generation wants to be sure of something before devoting themselves to it," says educationist and former Delhi University vice-chancellor Dinesh Singh. "Many of them derive satisfaction from creating something themselves and would like to explore different opportunities before deciding on a career path." And if their best plans go awry? Then, there's always something else. "I'm not scared of quitting a job and starting with a different industry from scratch. It's better to